



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 15: Role of Positivity in Public Speaking

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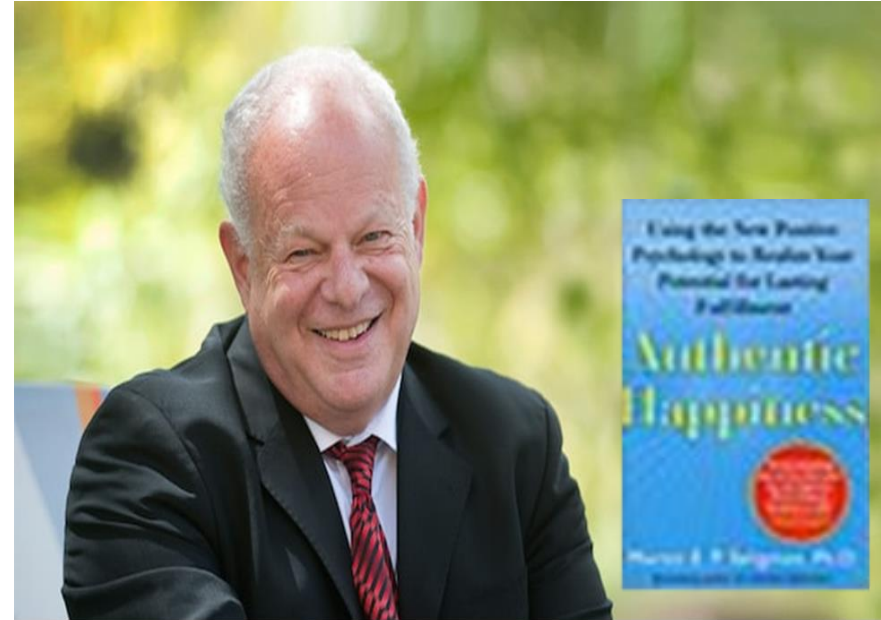
Defining Positive Thinking

“Positive thinking is a positive mental attitude that firmly believes that things will soon be better and with that belief, one can overcome any type of difficulty in his favor.”

- Norman Vincent Peale

Positive Psychology

- Propounded by **Martin Seligman**
- *“Positive psychology is the scientific study of what makes life most worth living”* (Peterson, 2008).
- Positive psychology focuses on strengths instead of weaknesses.
- The prime focus of positive psychology is on character strengths, optimism, well-being, self-esteem, self-confidence, gratitude, hope and compassion.



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Positive Attitude

- ***“People may hear your words, but they feel your attitude.” – John C. Maxwell***
- In any form of communication, the speaker should connect with the audience on multiple levels - linguistic, paralinguistic, non-verbal - in order to deliver the intended meaning.
- Attitude plays an important role in establishing communication.
- Positive attitude can act like a catalyst in achieving desired outcomes.

“There is nothing either good or bad,
but thinking makes it so.”
- Rosencrantz from Hamlet

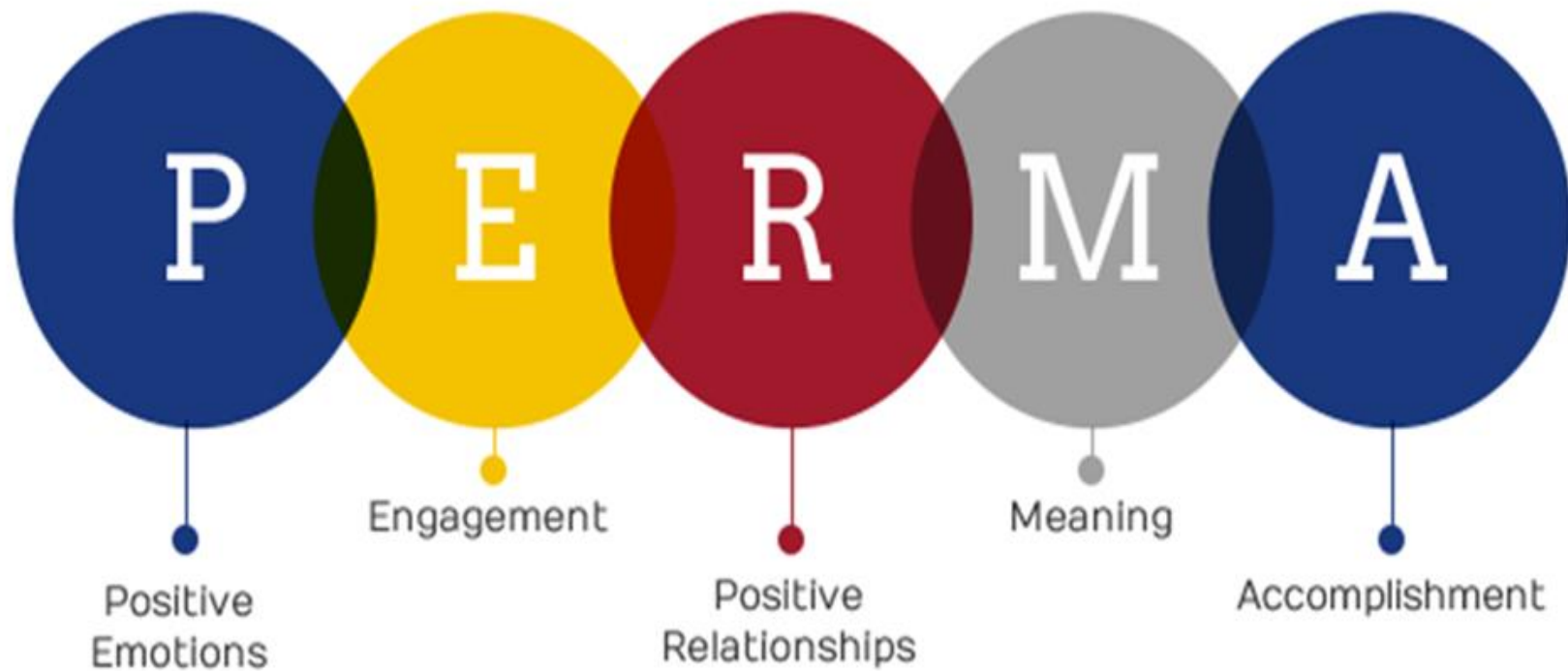
Three Types of Happiness	Examples	Causes
Life Satisfaction	• I think my life is great • I am satisfied with my job	• A good income • Achieving one's goals • High self-esteem
Positive Feelings	• Enjoying life • Loving others	• Supportive friends • Interesting work • Extroverted personality
Low Negative Feelings	• Few chronic worries • Rarely sad or angry	• Low neuroticism • One's goals are in harmony • A positive outlook

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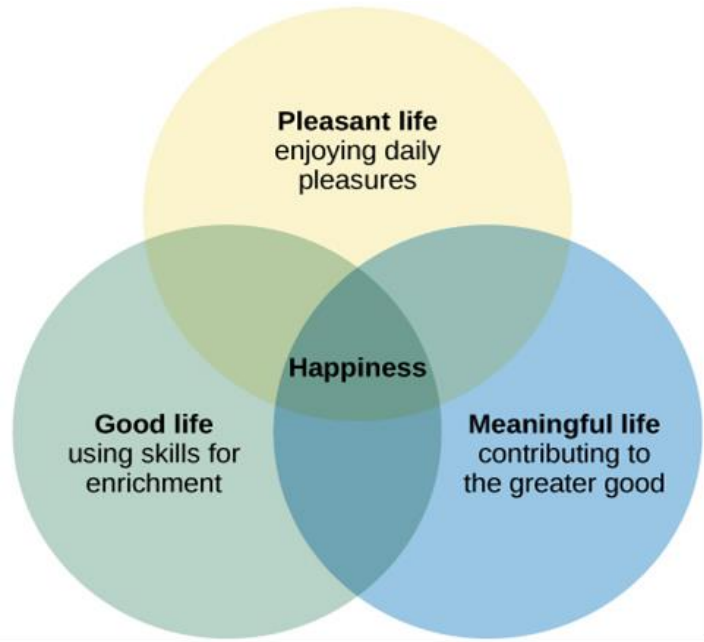
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- “Positive psychology takes you through the countryside of pleasure and gratification, up into the high country of strength and virtue, and finally to the peaks of lasting fulfillment, meaning and purpose” (Seligman).
- **PERMA** is an acronym devised by Martin Seligman which refers to the components of “good life.”



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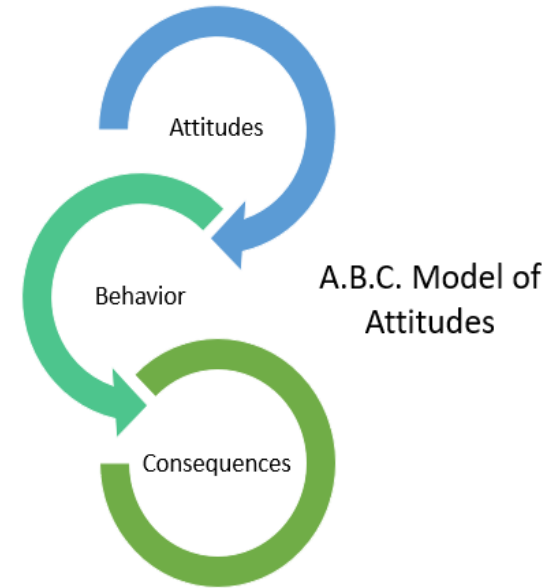
Impacts of Positive Psychology



- ❖ Positive emotions boost confidence and drastically improve our job performance.
- ❖ It is contagious in any given situation.
- ❖ Simple actions impact happiness.
- ❖ Positive emotions increase the chances of success.

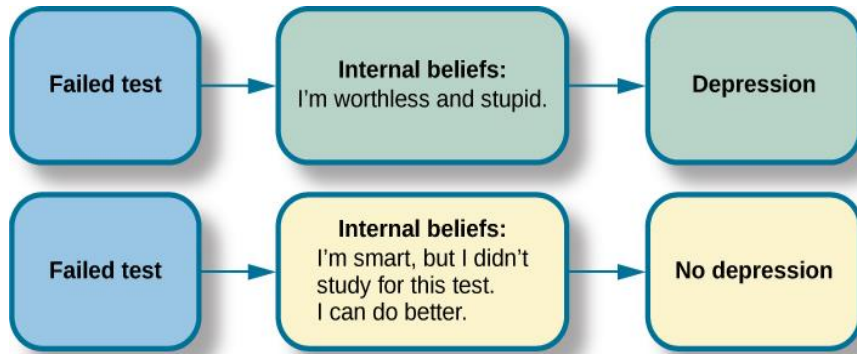
ABC Model of Communication Attitude

- The ABC model was first formulated by American psychologist, Albert Ellis.
- The model was a part of Rational-Emotive Therapy (RET) and Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CBT).
- The acronym stands for its three key components:
 - Attitudes/ Affect
 - Belief/ Behavior
 - Consequences/ Cognition

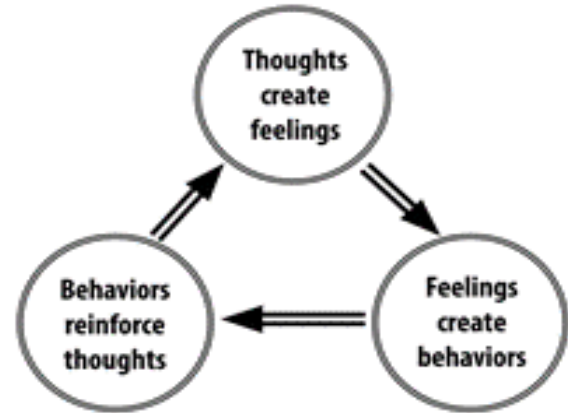


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- This model essentially helps one to check one's attitude during a period of high adversity or stress.
- It is relevant to public speaking when the speaker could analyze 'active ingredients' of an issue and then deliver upon a problem situation.



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Opting Positive Content to Deliver

- ❖ Positive communication does not always entail informative content; it can be phatic too.
- ❖ Phatic communication includes greetings and utterances such as “*nice meeting you!*”.
- ❖ It usually incorporates a constructive approach to lead a conversation, including criticism.
- ❖ Communication emulates good emotions for both the speaker and listener in an implicit manner.
- ❖ Intention, adaptation and active listening also serve as essential to establish positive communication.



Positive Thinking to Positive Talk

- Research suggests that one's personal and social well-being is essentially determined by the positive nature of their communication abilities (Albada and Moore 117).
- Communicative choices are primarily influenced by one's cognitive development.
- Research conducted by Shadinger et al. on pre-speech positive self-talk explains how employing self-affirming statements reduces performance anxiety.



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Coping Speech Anxiety through Positive Thinking

- Communication anxiety has been attributed to a variety of reasons, such as:
 1. **Skill deficits:** Lacking necessary experience and performance abilities.
 2. **Conditioning:** Past communicative experiences of negative consequences.
 3. **Cognitive:** Lack of self-awareness and complexity crisis.
- Joe Ayres, in his study elucidates the power of positive thinking to cope with speech anxiety.
- He deduces **visualisation** as an efficient tool “to reduce speech anxiety and increased the proportion of positive to negative thoughts speakers reported having before, during and after a speech.” (294)

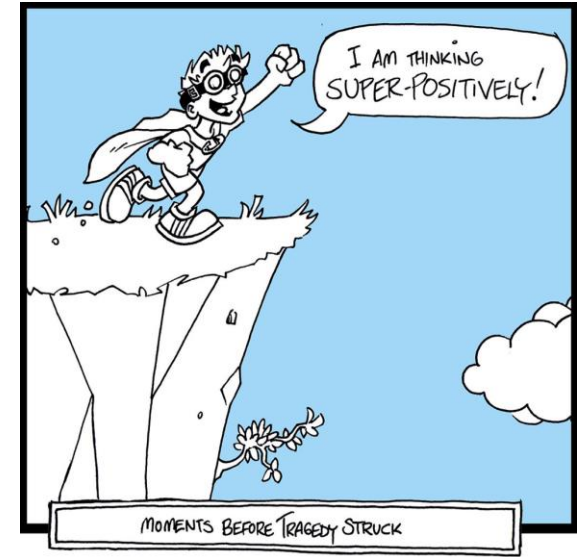
Benefits of Positive Thinking

- ❖ The ability to adapt communication with respect to the external situations and changes is an integral quality of a good public speaker.
- ❖ Scheier and Carver (28) suggested that optimists fare better in adapting to stressful situations than pessimists.
- ❖ Positive thinking as a quality is seen to be determined by categories of both nature and nurture.
- ❖ However, it is undoubtedly possible to nurture positive communication skills through practice and experience.



Limits of Positive Thinking

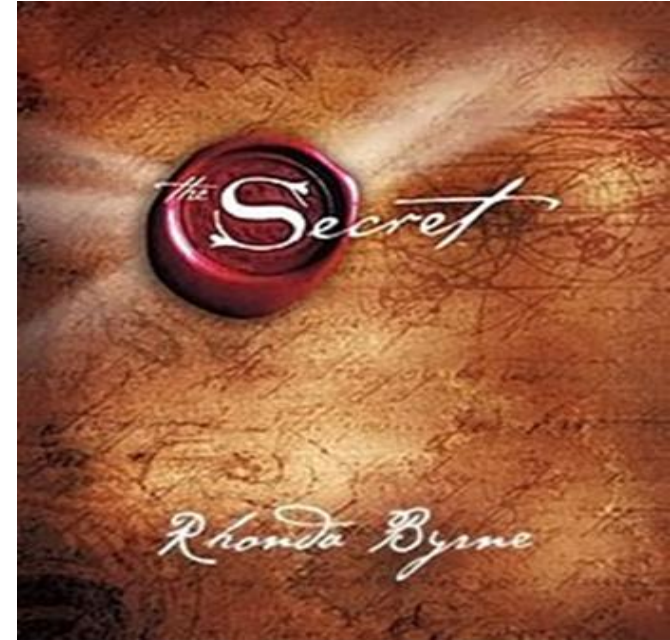
- ❖ Scheier and Carver (28-29) also notice the limitations of optimism in the cases of:
 - ❖ Unbridled optimism.
 - ❖ Maladaptive optimism
- ❖ Collinson (91) had elaborated on the tyranny of positive thinking as a cult fashion statement.
- ❖ Positive thinking, at times, can also become “disciplinary pressure and obligatory organizational practice” (Fineman, 280).



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List of Books on Positive Thinking

- ***The Power of Positive Thinking*** by [Norman Vincent Peale](#)
- ***Humankind: Changing the World One Small Act At a Time*** by [Brad Aronson](#)
- ***As a Man Thinketh*** by [James Allen](#)
- ***The Secret*** by [Rhonda Byrne](#)
- ***Think and Grow Rich*** by Napoleon Hill



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“The positive thinker sees the invisible,
feels the intangible,
and achieves the impossible.”
– Winston Churchill

Be Positive

Thank You

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